

The Dance School Awards: Industry Award - Dance School of the Year

Dance School of the Year Application / Nomination Questions.

Please find below 5 questions which we will need you to answer to proceed with your nomination.

Judges will consider:

- Clear, specific achievements from the past year and why they matter.
- Evidence of positive impact on students, staff, or the wider community.
- A clearly articulated ethos and set of values.
- Thoughtful support for students with different goals and pathways.
- Clear safeguarding procedures embedded in everyday practice.
- Awareness of student wellbeing and duty of care.
- Evidence of commitment to equity, diversity, and inclusion in policies, practice, and culture.
- Strong leadership and professional standards.
- A compelling overall case for why the school stands out.

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Steppin' Out Academy of Performance

1. Tell us 3 things you are you most proud of your school achieving in the last year. *

1. Creating Outstanding Performance Opportunities

We create bespoke shows yearly that encompass dance, acting and singing. Every student is a part of the creative process as we bring in leading Broadway and West End producers to workshop the show and develop the storyline. The music is customer arranged to suit each performer. The whole show process gives an outstanding opportunity to experience how a professional show is developed and gives them a unique insight into the stages of a development of a show. Our students follow the same pathway as a professional performer from the audition process through to the final bow.

2. Supporting Individual Student Growth

We are incredibly proud of the progress our students make both on and off the stage. Whether a student joins us to build confidence, make friends, stay active, or pursue a professional career, we celebrate every achievement and are committed to helping each individual reach their personal goals.

One of our greatest rewards is witnessing the transformation in our students. We have seen young people arrive as shy, reserved, and lacking in confidence, only to grow into self-assured individuals who are able to express themselves, communicate confidently, and embrace new challenges. The skills they develop at our academy extend far beyond performance, helping them succeed in school, relationships, and everyday life.

3. Strengthening Our School Community

Our Academy has continued to grow and evolve while maintaining the warm, supportive, family atmosphere that lies at the heart of everything we do. As we have expanded opportunities across all performing arts disciplines, we have remained committed to ensuring that every student feels valued, encouraged, and part of a welcoming community.

This year, we took our commitment to inclusion and community impact even further by establishing a fundraising committee and Community Interest Company (CIC). Through these initiatives, we are working to remove barriers to participation, support local children and families, and create opportunities for young people who may not otherwise have access to performing arts training. We are incredibly proud that our growth has enabled us not only to enrich the lives of our own students but also to make a positive difference within the wider community.

2. How would you describe your school's ethos and values? *

At Steppin' Out Academy of Performance, we believe that every child deserves the opportunity to shine. Our ethos is built around inclusivity, encouragement, respect, excellence, and personal growth. We strive to create a nurturing environment where students feel safe to challenge themselves, develop confidence, and express their individuality. We celebrate effort as much as achievement and encourage students to support one another, building strong friendships and a genuine sense of community. Our values extend beyond performing arts. We aim to develop kind, resilient, hardworking young people who carry the skills and confidence they gain at our academy into all areas of their lives.

3. How do you support both recreational and aspiring professional students? *

We are passionate about providing opportunities for every student, regardless of their ambitions. For recreational students, we offer a welcoming and enjoyable environment where they can learn new skills, build confidence, stay active, and form lasting friendships without pressure. Success is measured through personal development, enjoyment, and achievement of individual goals. For students aspiring to professional careers, we provide additional training opportunities, examination pathways, competition experiences, performance opportunities, audition preparation, mentoring, and industry guidance. Many of our students have progressed into professional training programmes, performing arts colleges, and industry opportunities. Importantly, both pathways are equally valued. Every student receives the same level of encouragement, care, and support, and we celebrate all achievements, whether they occur on a local stage or a professional platform.

4. What does safe guarding and student wellbeing look like in practice at your school? *

Safeguarding and wellbeing are at the heart of everything we do. We have clear safeguarding policies and procedures in place, regular staff training, designated safeguarding leads, and robust communication systems with parents and carers. In practice, safeguarding means creating an environment where students feel safe, heard, and respected. Our staff take time to build positive relationships with students, allowing them to feel comfortable sharing concerns or seeking support when needed. Student wellbeing is embedded into our daily culture. We recognise that every child is unique and may face different challenges. We promote positive self-esteem, celebrate individual achievements, encourage healthy attitudes towards performance and training, and ensure that students know their worth extends far beyond results, examinations, or competition outcomes.

5. Why do you believe your school deserves this award? *

Steppin' Out Academy of Performance deserves this award because we consistently place our students at the centre of everything we do. We have created a thriving, inclusive community where young people are encouraged to dream big, work hard, and believe in themselves.

Our commitment extends beyond teaching performing arts. We are developing confident, resilient, respectful young people while providing exceptional training, meaningful opportunities, and unwavering support for every student, regardless of ability or ambition.

The success of our academy is reflected not only in performances, examinations, and achievements, but in the confidence, happiness, and personal growth of our students. We are proud of the positive impact we have on our community and remain dedicated to inspiring the next generation both on and off the stage.

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